Fair Haven Family Table

Food, cooking, and community for Fair Haven families

STATUS	501(c)(3) public charity, Connecticut
FOUNDED	2012 (as a church food closet; independent since 2019)
BASED IN	Fair Haven, New Haven (church basement on Grand Avenue)
SERVES	Families in Fair Haven and Fair Haven Heights; many Spanish-speaking
ANNUAL BUDGET	About $95,000 (plus donated food valued at about $160,000)
STAFF	1 part-time coordinator (25 hrs/week)
VOLUNTEERS	About 60; a core group of 15 runs every pantry day
REACH	About 420 households a year; 150 to 190 each month

MISSION

Familia, comida y comunidad. Fair Haven Family Table makes sure no family in our neighborhood goes without healthy food, and that everyone who walks in leaves feeling welcomed, not judged.

OUR STORY

The pantry began as a shelf of canned goods in a church hallway. During 2020, demand tripled and neighbors stepped up to run it. The group incorporated as its own nonprofit so it could apply for grants and add cooking classes, which families had been asking for.

WHO WE SERVE

Households with children, older adults living alone, and recently arrived immigrant families. Roughly 65% of visitors prefer Spanish. Many work jobs with irregular hours, so the pantry is open one evening and one Saturday morning a week.

PROGRAMS

Choice Pantry
Families shop the shelves like a small market and choose what they want, including fresh produce from a regional food bank and a farm partner. Twice a week.

Cocina Juntos (Cooking Together)
Monthly bilingual cooking classes using pantry ingredients, taught by neighborhood cooks. Children cook alongside parents. About 15 families per class.

Home Delivery for Seniors
Volunteers deliver a box every other week to about 30 homebound older adults and stay to chat.

HOW WE'RE FUNDED

Faith communities (35%), a regional food bank partnership (in-kind), small foundation grants (30%), individual donors (25%), and a neighborhood restaurant fundraiser (10%).

WHAT WE TRACK TODAY

Household visit counts and family size (paper sign-in, typed up monthly). Pounds of food distributed, as reported to the food bank. Class sign-ups. No follow-up with families.

WHAT WE'RE WRESTLING WITH

Counting pounds of food doesn't say whether families are healthier or less stressed. The coordinator wants to show the value of the cooking classes and the senior visits, which feel like the heart of the work but have no numbers.

A MOMENT FROM OUR WORK

An older man on the delivery route told a volunteer that the Thursday visit was the only conversation he had most weeks. The volunteer now brings her daughter, and the three of them play dominoes before she leaves.

(Details changed to protect privacy.)